The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Bloomberg via Getty Images

Donald Trump said he had ordered America's navy to "shoot and kill" boats putting mines in the Strait of Hormuz, and to increase its minesweeping efforts. He reiterated that America would maintain its naval blockade until Iran makes a deal. Iran has attacked at least three ships in the waterway and said it had detained two others since Mr Trump extended the ceasefire on Tuesday.

Meta will reportedly cut about 10% of its workforce—around 8,000 jobs—and scrap thousands of roles as it shifts resources towards artificial intelligence. Mark Zuckerberg, the company's boss, has warned that AI tools could replace some work done by engineers. The social-media giant is ramping up spending to catch up with rivals.

Intel's shares jumped about 15% after the American semiconductor giant reported stronger-than-expected first-quarter results and forecast robust sales for the current quarter. Demand for the chips used in data centres is rising as companies invest heavily in artificial intelligence. Intel is beginning to recover after years of falling behind rivals, helped by backing from investors and new deals to expand chip production.

The **European Union** approved a €90bn ($105bn) loan to **Ukraine**, and a 20th package of sanctions against Russia. Two-thirds of the loan is for defence spending. The package had been held up for months by Hungary and Slovakia, which had demanded that Ukraine repair the Druzhba pipeline, which supplies Russian oil to Europe via Ukraine. It finished repairs on Tuesday.

Lockheed Martin, an American **defence** colossus, reported disappointing first-quarter results. Profits fell by 13%, compared with the same period last year, while sales remained flat. Inflation and Mr Trump's tariffs have weighed on growth, despite soaring demand for weapons in Europe and the Middle East. But Lockheed emphasised it has recently signed several agreements, including a $4.7bn contract to sell Patriot interceptors to America.

America's **Department of Commerce** said it would impose provisional tariffs on solar cells and panels from India, Indonesia and Laos, accusing producers of selling below fair value. The duties vary widely—reaching over 120% for some Indian imports—and mark the latest escalation in a years-long campaign against low-cost solar equipment from Asia.

France's weather-forecasting office alerted the police to suspicious temperature recordings that coincided with heavy betting on **Polymarket**, a prediction market. Traders placed $1.4m worth of bets on temperatures at Charles de Gaulle International Airport—far more than normal. On April 6th and 15th the airport's readings spiked in the evening; the forecasting office thinks they were tampered with.

Figure of the day: 95%, the chances of the Democrats flipping the House of Representatives. Explore our midterms forecaster.

Photograph: Getty Images

How long can the Iran ceasefire last?

It is becoming a familiar scene: a ticking clock, a threat of catastrophic war, a diplomatic scramble—and then, a last-minute reprieve. On Tuesday Donald Trump extended the ceasefire with Iran indefinitely, retreating again from his threats to bomb its power plants.

Both sides believe they have the upper hand. Mr Trump maintains his naval blockade is crushing cash-strapped Iran. Iran will probably have to start cutting oil production within days as storage fills; a prolonged closure of its ports will also drive up prices of food and other essentials. But Iran's regime believes that its own maritime stranglehold can force America to desist. Oil markets were unimpressed with the extended truce: the price of Brent crude stuck around $100 a barrel. Mr Trump needs the strait open before high petrol prices sink the Republicans' prospects in November's midterm elections. Both sides fear a resumption in fighting. Yet while each believes it is winning, neither wants to come to the negotiating table.

Photograph: Getty Images

The Indian art of wooing women

For a long time the female voter was an afterthought in Indian politics. Now, when electoral turnout among women often exceeds that of men, politicians have started to see them as a powerful voting bloc. In West Bengal and Tamil Nadu, which hold elections on Thursday, strategists are betting that cash is the way to get their support.

In West Bengal the chief minister, Mamata Banerjee, is campaigning on the popularity of her flagship cash-transfer scheme for women. Tamil Nadu's chief minister, M.K. Stalin, has promised that if he's re-elected he will double the state's cash benefit to women to around $20 per month. These are examples of a striking trend: at least 16 of India's 28 states run schemes that pay women cash—up from just a handful in 2022. Around half of these states run revenue deficits; such payments add to the strain. Women voters are now impossible to ignore. They are also expensive to please.

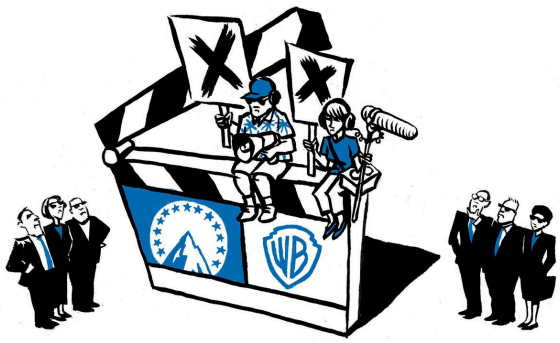

Illustration: David Simonds

A deal of Paramount importance

On Thursday Warner Bros Discovery's shareholders approved the company's takeover by Paramount, a much smaller Hollywood rival controlled by the Ellisons, who made their fortune in tech, despite a plot to derail the $111bn deal. Earlier this month more than 1,400 actors and filmmakers signed a letter arguing that it would "consolidate an already concentrated media landscape".

The acquisition is likely to face legal challenges on antitrust grounds. "WarnerMount" has a decent defence. Combining the two century-old studios is bound to result in job losses, and may lead to fewer productions (the Ellisons have promised to ramp up film-making but they will need to slash costs to pay down debt from the highly leveraged takeover). Yet at the moment, Warner is struggling to compete with streaming giants such as Netflix, Disney and Amazon. Paramount, smaller still, is probably doomed without a partner. Merging Hollywood's old studios may be better for competition than letting them wither.

Photograph:

Data bite: Corporate America shrugs off global tumult

Despite the shock of Donald Trump's trade war, and now a real one in the Gulf, earnings expectations for American firms are through the roof. Aggregate earnings for the S&P 500 rose by an estimated 19% in the first quarter, year on year. Projections for earnings growth for the next 12 months are 24% higher than a year ago. That would beat even the profit bonanza that followed the corporate-tax cuts of Mr Trump's first term. AI is driving some of the windfall. But even outside big tech, earnings are set to increase by 16% in 2026—a testament to American innovation, especially in AI and pharmaceuticals, which remains the envy of the world.

In sickness and in health...

S&P 500

1 WHO declares covid-19 a pandemic

2 Russia invades Ukraine

3 Trump's "Liberation Day" **4** US attacks Iran

Source: LSEG Workspace

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which Malaysian state is bordered by Negeri Sembilan to the north and Johor to the east?

Wednesday: Which Portuguese explorer was the first European to cross the Pacific?

Language is the main instrument of man's refusal to accept the world as it is.

George Steiner